

Scientist Network for Advancing Policy (SNAP)

snapcoalition.org/
Policy Hackathon 2026

Policy <> Track C

Climate & Energy Policy

About This Track:

This challenge is part of the Policy Hackathon 2026 C track: Climate / Energy. Design a decarbonization or resilience policy that balances environmental, economic, and equity goals.

Use Case Description:

This challenge asks teams to design a decarbonization or climate-resilience policy that balances environmental, economic, and equity goals for a specific jurisdiction — city, state, or national.

Problem Statement:

Balancing environmental, economic, and equity goals in a decarbonization or resilience policy.

- Select a focus: clean energy siting/permitting, grid reliability & AI data-center load, community-level decarbonization, climate finance/carbon markets, or climate adaptation/resilience.
- Establish the baseline (emissions, energy mix, or vulnerability data) for the chosen jurisdiction.
- Survey existing policy tools (incentives, mandates, carbon pricing, permitting reform).
- Propose a policy package with a phased implementation timeline.
- Model likely economic, environmental, and equity/community impacts.

Possible Approaches:

- Permitting reform — streamlined siting rules with community-benefit safeguards.
- Market-based — a carbon pricing, cap-and-trade, or credit mechanism.
- Grid/tech — address AI-data-center load growth (rate design, interconnection reform).
- Community power — center a labor/union or frontline-community partnership model.

Challenge Duration:

- Teams start working in September 2026
- Submission on **November 14, 2026**. There will be no extension to the submission deadline.

Team Guidelines:

- Team size — **3–5 participants per team, interdisciplinary encouraged.**
- Ensure you are enrolled as a participant in Policy Hackathon 2026.
- Everyone is eligible to participate in this challenge and win awards.
- Standout teams may be invited to brief partner organizations or judges directly on their proposal.

Challenge Tasks / Deliverables:

- 4–6 page policy brief with baseline data and a phased implementation plan
- One-page fact sheet suitable for public/media release

- Slide deck (8–10 slides)
- Simple quantitative model or estimate of emissions/cost impact
- Process appendix (0.5 page)

Optional Advanced Tasks:

- Interactive chart/dashboard visualizing baseline vs. projected impact
- Draft model legislative or regulatory text
- Mini stakeholder mapping exercise
- Scenario-test against a supply shock or extreme weather event

Platforms and Tools:

- Data: EIA, EPA GHG inventories, NREL data tools, state PUC filings
- Modeling: Excel/Sheets, Python (pandas), or simple emissions calculators
- Legislative tracking: Congress.gov, state legislature sites, Regulations.gov

Judging Criteria:

- Technical/scientific accuracy — **20%**
- Political & economic feasibility — **20%**
- Equity/community impact analysis — **20%**
- Quality of quantitative modeling — **20%**
- Clarity & presentation — **20%**

Data Privacy / Eligibility Restriction:

- Use only public emissions/energy data — no proprietary utility data without explicit permission.
- Consent and anonymization required for any community interviews.
- Disclose AI tool use and modeling assumptions/limitations transparently.

Participants retain ownership of their submissions but grant Scientist Network for Advancing Policy (SNAP) the right to evaluate, discuss, and showcase submitted work for educational and research purposes, with appropriate attribution.